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Instead of Comparing: Words That Build Self-Worth

For parents and grandparents · Ages 2–4

Young children build their picture of themselves from how the important adults in their lives describe them. Comparison paints them as 'less than'. These swaps help them see their own growth.

What we know

- ○ Children's self-concept forms largely through the messages and appraisals of the adults close to them (Harter, 2012).
- ○ Developmental milestones have wide normal ranges. Two healthy 2-year-olds can be months apart in speech or motor skills.

Swap this...

- ○ “Look, Riya already reads!” → “You know so many letter sounds now.”
- ○ “Your brother never did this.” → “This is hard for you. Let's work on it.”
- ○ “Why can't you be like him?” → “You're good at different things.”
- ○ “Say the poem for aunty!” → “He'll share when he's ready.”

Compare them to their past self

- ○ “Last month you needed help with this. Now you do it alone!”
- ○ “Remember when this puzzle was too hard?”
- ○ Keep a small 'I can' list on the fridge and add to it.

At family gatherings

- ○ Prepare your child: “Lots of people will say hello. You can wave or say namaste.”
- ○ Answer for them when needed, kindly but firmly.
- ○ Talk to grandparents beforehand about avoiding comparisons.

When to check

If you're worried your child is far behind in speech, movement or play, speak to your paediatrician. Concern is not comparison.

SOURCES AND FURTHER READING

Harter, S. (2012). The Construction of the Self: Developmental and Sociocultural Foundations (2nd ed.). Guilford Press.

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